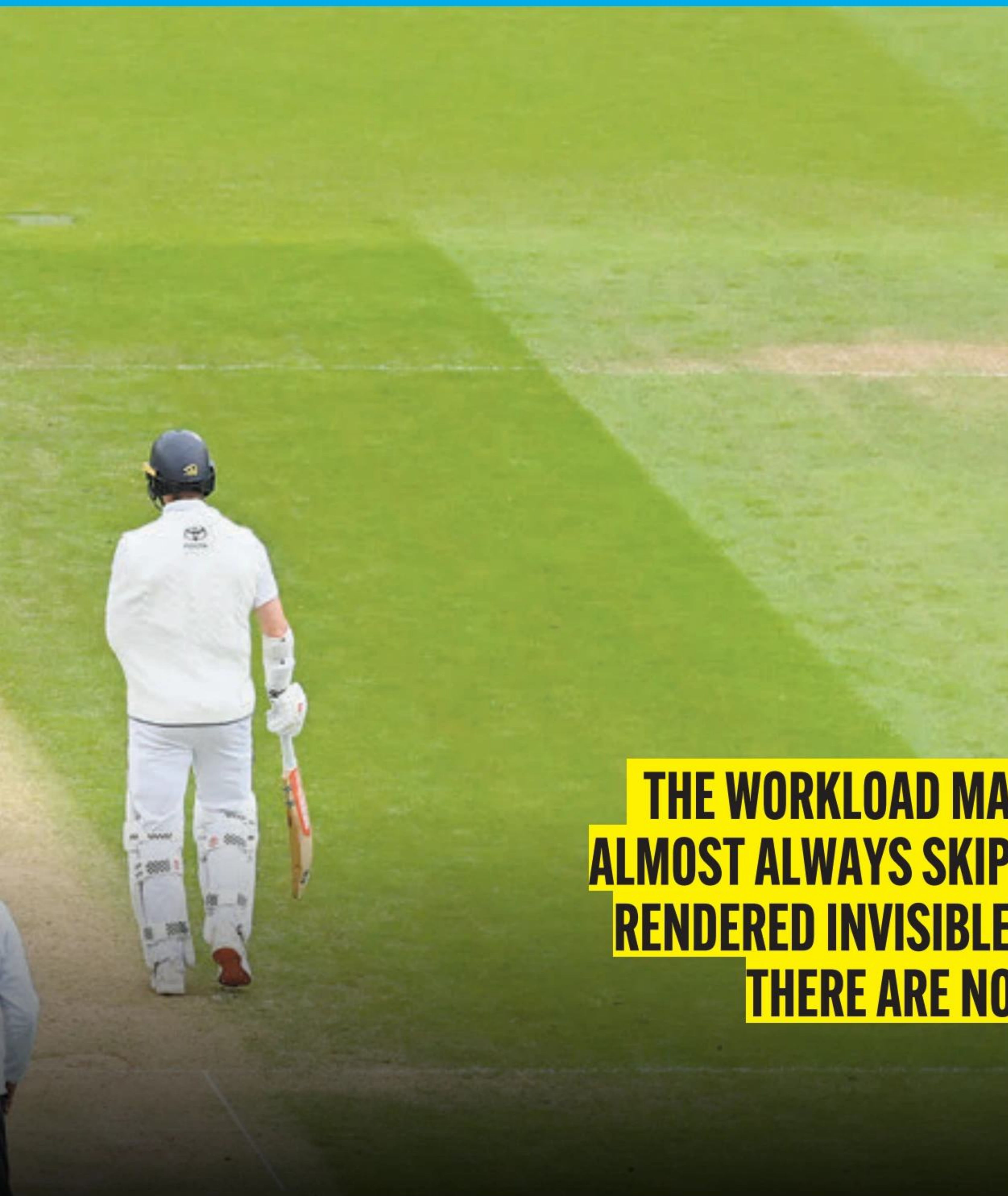




Marathon man: Mohammed Siraj delivered 30.1 overs in the fourth innings at The Oval to help India earn a win and draw the five-match series.

Pics: GETTYIMAGES

for it with tenacity and superhuman endurance. His relentless eight-over spell on the second day at The Oval bears testimony. Making amends for a four-over first spell that went for 32 runs, Siraj pinned Ollie Pope and Joe Root in front with his go-to nip-backer from a good length before trapping Jacob Bethell in front with an in-swinging yorker — the only one he bowled in that spell, which he relished as his favourite scalp.

THE WORKLOAD MANAGEMENT STRICTURES ALMOST ALWAYS SKIP SIRAJ, AS THOUGH HE IS RENDERED INVISIBLE BY HIS OMNIPRESENCE. THERE ARE NO CALLS TO ‘WRAP HIM IN COTTON WOOL’

And yet, there was no let-up in intensity from Siraj until all the drama had been squeezed out of the series, all the gods invoked, and all the fingernails chewed. Siraj whips up an easy hostility at the snap of a finger and plays the pantomime villain from time to time, but there is no element of a supernatural aura, one that hovers around his *Jassi bhai* [Jasprit Bumrah] — a transcendental figure in India's bowling attack.

He is the salt of the earth, a 'really nice lad' despite the odd argy-bargy, and in the age of Instagram reels, simply needs a Google search-inspired wallpaper to make him 'believe'. He is a captain's dream who provides maximum output with minimum input, a commodity that often accompanies the 'workhorse' tag that puts quantity over quality.

But Siraj is far from just filling in the overs, holding one end up and buying recovery time for the rest of the attack. He elevates the contest and has the skill, in the absence of Bumrah, to emerge as the face of India's charge. During the Anderson-Tendulkar Trophy series, he picked 16 wickets at 19.81 apiece in the two games Bumrah couldn't play, a significant level up from his seven wickets at an average of 61.28 when the maverick was present.

"When *Jassi bhai* isn't around, then you get that confidence that you need to shoulder extra responsibility, and I enjoy that. I don't take extra pressure and try to keep things simple," Siraj had said after nabbing four wickets in the first innings at The Oval against England.

If Siraj lacks artistry, he makes up

For the glut of overs he has bowled, Siraj's planning and execution is astonishingly accurate.

His third yorker of the match saw the ball scuttle through Zak Crawley's defence off the final delivery of the third day and tipped the scales in India's favour.

With the ball paying homage to the bat for the last part of the penultimate day, Siraj once again broke England's resistance by darting the ball into Pope's pads from a good length at the stroke of lunch and then unleashing hell across a 12.1-over spell spread over two days.

A misstep of an inch at the fine-leg boundary, which resulted in Siraj handing centurion Harry Brook a six instead of dismissing him on 19, had threatened to sour an otherwise phenomenal series. But ubiquity is a double-edged sword; as much as it allows room for more error, it also